INTRODUCTION TO PARAGRAPH WRITING

What is a paragraph?

In academic writing, these features are expected in an expository or argumentative paragraph:

1. A topic sentence
2. Supporting sentences
3. Proper referencing of sources
4. A concluding sentence

These features are organised coherently. Coherence may be achieved by using:

1. Linking words or phrases
2. Given-to-new progression
3. Repeating keywords/synonyms
4. Associated words

Read the following two passages and make a note of which features and coherence devices you find.

Passage A

One major difference between growing up in a city and in a rural area is the degree of friendliness among neighbors. In large cities, residents often live in large apartment buildings with hundreds of strangers. These urban apartment dwellers tend to be wary of unknown faces and rarely get to know their neighbors well. As Haggis noted, when surrounded by many strangers living closely together, urban residents tend to guard their privacy (2006). On the other hand, the situation in a small town is often just the opposite. Small-town residents generally grow up together, attend the same schools and share long-term family friendships. As a result, rural people are much more likely to get to know their neighbors and may even treat their close neighbors like family members. Thus, the degree of friendliness is very different between those who grow up in a city and those who grow up in a rural area.

Passage B

We would also like to argue that feedback alone is not effective. Along with Hyland (1990), we believe that learners need to reflect on, respond to, and act upon feedback for learning to occur. In the present study, professors' feedback led students to mutually engage, develop an understanding of the shared repertoire in their disciplines, and fine tune their texts in their subsequent writings. The students acted upon the feedback they received from peers and professors, constantly interacted with it, and mutually engaged with other students to make sense of the feedback. These activities provided the students with learning opportunities beyond attendance in lectures and tutorials and resulted in higher quality written texts.

Sources:

Folse, K. S., Muchmore-Vokoun, A., & Solomon, E. V. (2010). Great writing 4: Great essays (3rd Ed). Heinle Cengage Learning.

Mirzaee, A., & Hasrati, M. (2014). The role of written formative feedback in inducing non-formal learning among master's students. *Teaching in Higher Education, 19*(5), 555-564.

PARAGRAPH UNITY AND COHERENCE

Paragraphs should have both coherence and unity. A paragraph with unity develops a single idea thoroughly and links it to the rest of the paper. Paragraph coherence is achieved when sentences are ordered in a logical manner and when clear transitions link sentences.

Paragraph unity:

- Develop a paragraph around a major idea.
- Express this idea in the topic sentence. Make the relationship between the main idea of the paragraph and the thesis of the paper clear. Do not assume that the readers will "get it." Spell it out for them.
- Support the main idea of the paragraph with details.
- Create separate paragraphs for those details that explore your topic from different perspectives.
- Eliminate sentences that do not support the main idea. Alternately, you may revise the main idea to include those sentences.

Look at the following examples from a paper that has the thesis: "Despite the amount of foreign aid pouring in, social conditions in Zeeland remain bleak because the aid is used for military purposes."

> Example 1 (without unity)
> Robert Bee wrote, "The Zeeland massacre illustrates the need for greater control of foreign aid." This is related to the thesis. Some 20,000 people disappeared from the villages. Financial mishandling can lead to great misfortune. Corruption in the government was exposed repeatedly to no avail. A police force, under orders to eliminate suspected terrorists, grabbed political dissidents and their families.
>
> Example 2 (unified)
> The pogrom of May 3, 1987 exemplifies how foreign aid funds were appropriated for repressive rather than social development purposes. On that day, some 20,000 people were abducted from villages in the countryside, charged as traitors and summarily executed. Previously, Governor-for-life Zeely Zeelafsun had used $5 billion in aid to create a standing paramilitary police force. Without some restrictive control over the aid, human rights organizations were unable to prevent Zeelafsun's actions and the unleashing of this disaster. Robert Bee, the director of the Development as Freedom Foundation wrote, "The Zeeland massacre illustrates the need for greater control of foreign aid."

In the first paragraph it is hard to tell what the topic sentence is, let alone how all the sentences belong together. The reader is not informed who Robert Bee is. The words "related to" in the second sentence do not give the reader any sense of what the relationship is. The second paragraph provides a tight topic sentence that links the main idea of the paragraph to the central argument of the paper. It eliminates details that do not fall under the topic and adds details that are relevant to the reader's understanding of the events and their relation to foreign aid.

Paragraph coherence:
Decide on an order for your sentences that will best develop the paragraph's main idea. Your supporting sentences are raw materials. They will not make sense to a reader unless they are put in order.

This order could be based on several factors:

- Chronological sequence: This is useful for describing a sequence of events.
- Modified chronology: Sometimes a major idea presented early in a paragraph can be supplemented with necessary background information.
- Spatial position of different objects: This method is useful for description.
- 'Conversation' between different experts: By moving between a series of key positions, a writer can establish a sense of dialogue and develop a complex argument.
- Logical form of argument: Some form of logical proof, like a syllogism, can serve as the basis for order.

Once you have put your sentences in order, express the connections between them with transitional words or phrases. Think of these as signposts to guide the reader through your paragraph. They should be clear.

Examples (transitions in bold):

1) Chronological sequence
Topic sentence: Our journey was filled with misfortune and luck.

- **After the car broke down**, we had to walk several miles.
- **Having eaten little for lunch**, we were soon wearied.
- **While we wanted to continue toward town**, we had to rest.
- **It was at that moment** that a truck driver offered us a ride.

2) Expert Conversation
Topic sentence: Karl Marx and Michel Foucault produced influential and superficially similar but ultimately conflicting understandings of the way that power struggles determine truth.

- **Marx, writing in the mid-nineteenth century, asserted** that truth was the product of conflicts between classes, or groups of people positioned differently in historical economic power arrangements.
- **While agreeing with** Marx's recognition of the way that power struggles and history alter truth, Foucault was more skeptical about Marx's identification of classes as the primary actors in the struggle.
- **Instead**, Foucault suggested that an examination of the claims made about sexuality and appropriate punishments revealed a complex give-and-take between various social groups and interests, all of which sought to establish dominance by controlling meaning.
- Marxist critics of Foucault **argue in response** that removing the focus from class eliminates a broad view of social conflict necessary to understand how economic and political changes shape our everyday understanding.

Adapted from

American University, Academic Support Center, Writing Lab. (updated 2009) Retrieved July 15, 2020, from https://www.american.edu/provost/academic-access/upload/paragraph-unity-and-coherence.pdf